AI FOR MANAGERS · STUDY GUIDE

Scout — Finding Where AI Can Add Real Value

Where could AI meaningfully improve our work, and how do I know it's worth adopting?

MODULE 5 · LESSON 5 | LEAD: CAPABILITY | Action lesson · 7–9 min

THE CORE IDEA

Staying ahead means deliberately looking for where AI adds value — and testing it with evidence before it becomes how the team works.

If no one is deliberately looking, the team quietly falls behind while everything still feels fine.

1 The deliberate look

Amplify spreads and keeps what the team has already learned. **Scout** looks the other way — at what nobody has tried yet. Your team may be running well, but AI is moving fast, and so is everyone you compete with — and slow steps, missed tools, and sharper competitors never announce themselves. Scout is the deliberate look: where could AI genuinely move the needle for this team — its capacity, its quality, your product or service, your edge? Not AI for its own sake. If this sounds like innovation or process optimization, it is: the same discipline, pointed at AI, at the scale of your own team. The loop: spot the opportunity, test it, adopt what proves out.

2 Spot the opportunity

Two kinds of signal point to a real opportunity. **Inside the team's work**: a task that takes real time, repeatedly; a recurring quality or rework problem; a bottleneck holding up decisions, delivery, or customers. **Outside it**: a tool the team already uses adds a capability worth a look, or a comparable team or competitor gets results from an approach you haven't tried. A light pulse outward is enough — and you're scouting for your own team, not running pilots across the business. A few times a year — the quarterly review is a natural home — put two questions to the team:

THE TWO TEAM QUESTIONS

1. "Where is repeated work, rework, inconsistency, or a bottleneck costing us — in capacity, quality, decisions, customers, or risk?"
2. "Has anyone tried AI for something the rest of us haven't picked up yet?"

Note: the second is Amplify's learning question pointed forward — hunting for what's next, not catching what's already happening.

A signal on its own isn't a reason to act. Test it against the **two impact questions**: **(1) Would fixing this genuinely help the team** — the time it involves, the people and downstream steps it touches, the effect on capacity, quality, decisions, customers, or risk? **(2) Would the gain be worth the setup and ongoing checking** — counting verification, coordination, and maintenance, not just headline time saved? The test is never "could AI do this?" — it's "would this meaningfully help, and is it worth the effort?" You come out with one qualified candidate.

3 Run the improvement loop

Test the candidate through a simple version of the continuous-improvement cycle teams have trusted for decades – **Plan, Do, Check, Act** – pointed at AI.

Plan – shape the trial

The trial is its own small project: someone owns it, it runs on one real task, and it has an end date. Name up front what a good result looks like – time saved, quality held, what you'd need to see to trust it.

Do & Check – run it and judge it

Judge the result on three things: **value** – did it improve time, capacity, quality, or another outcome that matters? **Quality and judgment** – was it reliable, and what did the person still have to check or decide? **Risk and control** – what could go wrong if this became routine; do the existing checkpoints cover it, or does the Checkpoint Map need updating?

Act – decide

Three calls: **Adopt** – agree the change with the team, update the Team Working Standard, adjust affected checkpoints. **Hold** – useful but not ready; keep it as a reference, revisit later. **Escalate** – it works but needs a decision above your authority; package a decision-ready request, send it through the right channel, and keep the current approved way running until you hear back.

Then it comes around again: adopt feeds the next version of your standard, hold returns when the timing is better, and even "nothing worth pursuing right now" resets the clock to the next scan.

4 The framework is complete

Scout is the fourth and last Lead role. Your **Lead AI Adoption Plan** now holds all four – **Reinforce, Develop, Amplify, Scout** – and from here they run together as one ongoing way of leading adoption, much of it inside meetings and reviews you already run. With the Lead move complete, the whole framework is in place: **Assess, Align, Control, Lead**. What's left isn't another method – it's putting it all into motion.

WHAT TO DO DIFFERENTLY AFTER THIS LESSON

- Run one scan this week and record the Scout entry in your Lead AI Adoption Plan – "nothing worth pursuing right now, and why" is a real result, not a blank.
- Filter every signal through the two impact questions before committing effort.
- Trial before adopting: an owner, one real task, an end date, success named up front.
- Judge trials on value, quality and judgment, and risk and control – then adopt, hold, or escalate.
- Make the scan a habit: a few times a year, ideally in a review you already run.

Module 5 · Lead: Capability – the module that turns the standard into durable capability through four ongoing roles. Download with this lesson: **Handout D – Quarterly Review**. **Next: Module 6** – build your 60-Day Plan with the workbook and the completed example.